

TBD

Executive summary

The four supplied reference images establish a tightly unified visual identity for **The Horizon Archive**. They succeed not because they imitate literal late-1990s hardware limitations, but because they create the *feeling* of a lost pre-rendered adventure game screen: a static camera, one overwhelming discovery per scene, disciplined atmospheric depth, a quiet bottom narration box, and a world that feels older, stranger, and more intelligent than the player. The style is not “retro for nostalgia’s sake.” It is a deliberate method for preserving awe.

The governing principle is **mystery through abstraction**. The references consistently withhold information at exactly the right level. Silhouettes are readable, but not over-explained. Textures are painterly and faceted rather than clinically descriptive. Fog, pollen, damp air, heat shimmer, and cosmic haze prevent the world from becoming optically literal. The result is a visual language in which every frame feels discoverable, ceremonial, and playable rather than merely illustrative.

For production, the strongest implementation path is a **modern constrained pipeline**: linear color rendering, correct sRGB handling for color textures, linear/non-color handling for normal and data maps, mipmaps and texture streaming for environment art, platform-appropriate BC compression, instancing for repeated scenery, and restrained post effects for bloom, fog, tint, and final grading. Those technical foundations are directly supported by current engine and DCC documentation; what makes the aesthetic feel like *The Horizon Archive* is not technological primitivism, but disciplined refusal to over-resolve the image. ¹

This document translates the reference images into a studio-usable specification for concept art, fixed-camera 2D backgrounds, 3D assets, materials, shaders, and UI. It defines what is non-negotiable, what is flexible, how to keep scenes coherent across wildly different subjects, and how to QA every asset and shot against the same visual standard.

Reference image synthesis

What the four references prove

Across all four images, the frame format is effectively identical: a 16:9 composition with a persistent lower textbox occupying roughly one quarter of the frame. That consistency is not cosmetic. It is the principal device that makes each image read as a game screen rather than a standalone painting. It tells the player that the world is inspectable, narratable, and temporally paused.

The scene grammar is equally consistent. Every image uses a **fixed-camera adventure framing** with strong foreground, midground, and background separation. The meadow centers a single cathedral-scale relic in a vast living plain. The ruins image builds a ritual platform and monolith ring around one impossible

geometric instrument. The robot alley image shifts to an intimate dialogue distance while preserving the same atmosphere, material language, and textbox anchor. The volcanic city expands to a massive overlook shot, but still obeys the same rules: static camera, dominant subject hierarchy, atmosphere-first depth, and a blank narrative box below.

The material family recurs across all four references. The world is built from a triad of **dark stone**, **aged metal or ceramic**, and **controlled luminous/translucent matter**. In the meadow, the luminous matter is petal-glass and pollen. In the ruins, it is a violet internal core and warped cosmic light. In the robot alley, it is dying seam-light and reflected puddle glow. In the volcanic city, it becomes lava, warning glints, ceramic domes, and heat haze. Different biome; same ontology.

The palette logic is equally strict. Every image sits on a cool mineral base of black, indigo, violet, mauve, and ash, then allows one scene-specific accent family to dominate the wonder: pale green and dawn gold in the meadow, ultraviolet and stellar silver in the ruins, violet decay in the alley, ember orange and ceramic ash in the city. This is why the set feels cohesive even though the subjects are radically different.

Why each reference matters

The Meadow defines how beauty should function in this style. It proves that *The Horizon Archive* can be lush, floral, and bright without becoming whimsical or cute. The colossal bloom-engine reads simultaneously as organism, machine, monument, and scientific instrument. It is not “fantasy magic.” It is sacred biotechnology.

The Ruins define the project’s science-mythic register. The central polyhedral frame and warped galactic sky communicate physics-scale mystery without resorting to runes, portals, or generic glowing artifacts. The image proves that angular geometry, black stone, and disciplined violet light are enough to imply spacetime manipulation and ceremonial intelligence.

The Fallen Automaton defines intimate encounter staging. The camera is close, the environment is narrow, but the image still belongs to the same world because the atmosphere, palette, and material treatment remain identical. The robot is not an enemy or mascot; it is a damaged witness. This image is the emotional center of the style guide because it shows that “character” in this project means *archaeological personhood*.

The Underground City defines scale, social life, and scientific plausibility. It proves the style can support bustling civilization without collapsing into generic industrial sci-fi. Small suited figures, heavy habitat structures, and lava-as-infrastructure keep the scene grounded. The heat suits are important because they shift the image away from fantasy lava iconography toward environmental engineering and survival design.

Style system diagram

flowchart LR

```
A["Mystery through abstraction"] --> B["Fixed-camera adventure framing"]
A --> C["Ancient material family"]
A --> D["Palette discipline"]
A --> E["Atmosphere as depth"]
```

```

A --> F["Textbox as narrative anchor"]

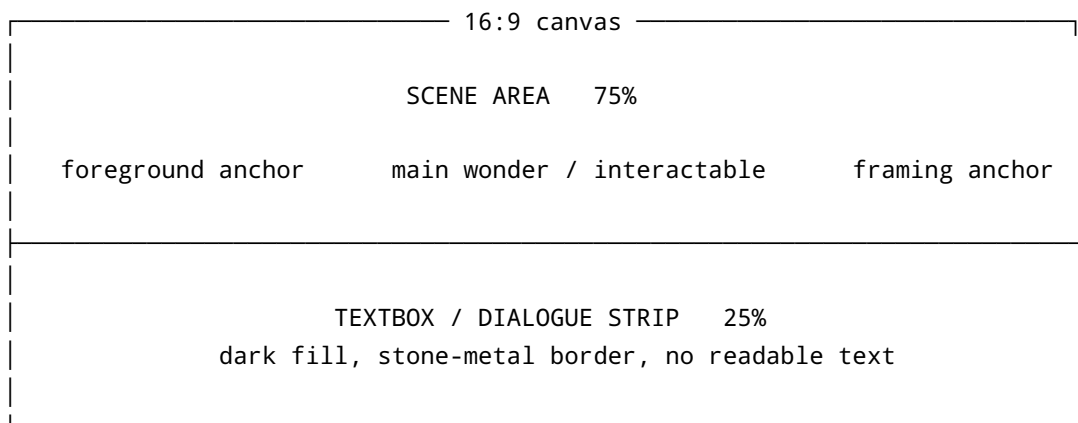
B --> G["Concept art and shot design"]
C --> H["3D assets and materials"]
D --> I["Color grading and light accents"]
E --> J["Fog, pollen, heat haze, damp air"]
F --> K["UI frame and blank dialogue strip"]

G --> L["Playable discovery feel"]
H --> L
I --> L
J --> L
K --> L

```

Schematic thumbnails

Thumbnail A — textbox placement



Thumbnail B — composition grid

left frame monolith / flowers	subject rise relic / city / character	right frame monolith / architecture
foreground scale cue	path / pool eye guide	foreground scale cue
reserved textbox band		

Thumbnail C — dither/detail behavior

Quiet surface field

Detail cluster near subject

Atmosphere bridge





· · · · pollen / fog / heat shimmer

low-frequency distance value changes

faceted texture, carvings, emissive seams, chipped edges

joins detail to

Rule: use visible texture breakup and optional ordered dither as a patina, not as a full-screen gimmick.

Visual system specifications

Core principle

Mystery through abstraction means the image must imply more than it describes. The player should feel that the world contains systems larger than the visible frame. As a production rule, every new shot should pass this test:

- If the subject is instantly explainable, remove detail or add ambiguity.
- If the subject is unreadable, strengthen silhouette and hierarchy.
- If the atmosphere is optically clean, the shot is too literal.
- If the image feels like concept art rather than a game screen, the textbox or fixed-camera grammar is underdeveloped.

One-sentence art direction

The Horizon Archive should look like a lost fixed-camera sci-fi adventure game from the late 1990s, where painterly low-poly abstraction, ancient alien materiality, disciplined atmosphere, and a silent bottom textbox turn every frame into a playable archaeological discovery.

Composition, camera framing, scale, and subject hierarchy

The references support a stable shot design language. Use the following rules as production defaults.

Parameter	Project rule	Working note
Canvas	16:9 only	Author all primary shots at fixed widescreen proportions
Scene/UI split	75% scene / 25% textbox	Non-negotiable visual anchor
Establishing lens	~32–45 mm equivalent	Wide enough for grandeur, narrow enough to avoid FPS distortion

Parameter	Project rule	Working note
Intimate encounter lens	~45–60 mm equivalent	Use for robot conversations or close relic inspection
Camera behavior	Static	No handheld feel, no action tilt, no dramatic roll
Subject occupancy	20–40% of total frame height	One dominant wonder, not many equal focal points
Foreground anchors	At least one	Monolith, flowers, railing, rubble, column, or puddle
Depth plan	Foreground / midground / background always explicit	Atmosphere should separate these layers
Scale cue	Mandatory	Small figures, stairs, pillars, grasses, platforms, bridges

Subject hierarchy should be authored in three tiers.

Tier one is the wonder: the bloom-engine, gravity relic, robot, or volcanic city core. It must read at thumbnail size.

Tier two is the guidance structure: obelisks, bridges, stairs, terraces, monoliths, alley walls, reflective pools. These elements lead the eye and provide scale.

Tier three is the atmospheric intelligence layer: dust, pollen, heat shimmer, distant windows, fog volumes, star distortion, shallow reflections, flora orientation. These elements make the world feel alive and ancient without overwhelming the composition.

Textbox design specifications

The textbox is not optional decoration. It is a persistent narrative device and should be treated like a formal UI object with strict proportions.

Parameter	1920×1080 target	3840×2160 target	Notes
Textbox outer height	270 px	540 px	25% of frame height
Scene visible height	810 px	1620 px	75% of frame height
Side margin	24–32 px	48–64 px	Box should nearly span width without touching edges
Bottom margin	14–24 px	28–48 px	Preserve a small grounding gap

Parameter	1920×1080 target	3840×2160 target	Notes
Border thickness	10–14 px	20–28 px	Keep trim thin and architectural
Corner chamfer	18–26 px	36–52 px	Octagonal / beveled sci-fi corners
Inner text safe padding	56–72 px	112–144 px	Relevant if final runtime text is added later
Fill	deep navy-black gradient	same	Center around #0B0B11 to #100F18
Border	stone-metal dark trim	same	Base around #272527 with edge hits near #494544
Readability policy	blank or unreadable in generated stills	blank or unreadable	No readable in-image text

Fill treatment. Use a near-black navy base with barely perceptible clouding or brushed noise. The box should feel deep, archival, and slightly absorbent, not glossy. A subtle vertical tonal shift is acceptable.

Border treatment. The trim should feel carved from the same universe as the environments: dark alloy, stone-metal laminate, slight bevel, faint wear on corners, and one or two geometric center notches. Avoid glowing UI strokes or sleek neon.

Texture treatment. Use very fine noise only. The box must never become visually busier than the landscape above it.

Color palette

The palette below is derived from the supplied reference images and normalized into reusable production swatches.

Name	Hex	Usage
Void Ink	#0B0B11	textbox fill, deepest occlusion, scene floor blacks
Archive Navy	#100F18	textbox gradient edge, night shadow wells
Basalt Char	#252627	ruins, carved stone, ribs, dark masonry
Deep Indigo	#2E304D	sky shadows, distant haze, wet-night scenes
Archive Violet	#383853	core cool midtone for most scenes
Horizon Violet	#504D6D	distant mountains, broad sky mids, atmospheric glue
Signal Lilac	#6F6687	emissive reflections, rim fills, cool light accents
Dust Mauve	#8C7790	dawn fog, floral highlights, cloud haze

Name	Hex	Usage
Faded Orchid	#A38E99	lift values, sky bloom, worn stone highlights
Ceramic Ash	#81837B	domes, ceramic shielding, UI edge wear
Archive Green	#708783	translucent bio-glass, oxidized mineral tint
Petal Lumen	#A3AB85	living relic accents, pale ecology highlights
Dawn Gold	#D1A9A5	low sun, sacred highlights, rare warm glints
Molten Ember	#A34B29	lava, furnace seams, hot-core accents
Lava Bronze	#624537	volcanic stone midtones, thermal grime

Use the palette in a **cool-base / singular-accent** structure. As a working rule, 60–70% of frame coverage should remain in cool dark mineral values. Scene-specific accents should occupy 15–25%. Emissive highlights should usually stay below 5% of image area.

Lighting and atmosphere

Lighting in this style is not about “showing the asset.” It is about staging discovery. Use low-key, directional, atmosphere-sensitive lighting and let the subject emerge from haze, reflection, or heat distortion rather than from uniformly even exposure.

Bloom should remain restrained and thresholded so that only true bright zones—lava, internal relic veins, small windows, or seed cores—produce a camera-overwhelm fringe. Unity’s bloom documentation explicitly defines bloom as bright-area glow with controllable intensity, threshold, diffusion, and performance mode; use that logic, but keep the effect sparse and scene-specific. Emissive materials should appear to glow through bloom instead of brute-force white clipping. ²

Ambient occlusion should be present but modest. Both Unity and Unreal describe AO as a crease-and-contact darkening effect, and Unreal specifically notes that it is generally best used as a subtle effect. In practice, do not use AO as fake dirt or black paint. Use it to anchor engravings, contact gaps, robot plate seams, and tight rock intersections. ³

Fog and local atmosphere are mandatory. Unreal’s volumetric fog system and local fog volumes, and Unity’s local Volume framework, are useful references because they all treat fog as a scene-defining spatial medium rather than a flat screen overlay. Use fog to separate planes, to bend light through relic petals, to make distant city districts recede, and to turn empty space into active mystery. Be aware that local volumetrics can carry meaningful performance cost, so lower-spec paths should substitute layered cards, painted haze, or cheaper depth fog. ⁴

For grading, use a filmic or ACES-like tonemapping approach. Unreal’s film section explicitly points to an ACES-standardized film stock model, and both Unreal and Blender document scene-linear to display conversion as a distinct technical and artistic stage. The practical implication is simple: do your lighting and material judgments in linear, preserve highlight headroom, and let the grade compress the world into its final mysterious darkness instead of baking clipped contrast into textures. ⁵

Negative constraints

The following are hard exclusions for the style:

- no photorealism
- no sterile next-gen realism
- no generic sleek sci-fi
- no anime, cartoon, mascot, or toy-like proportions
- no fantasy runes, castles, lava thrones, medieval dwarves, or hell imagery
- no glossy concept-art polish that resolves every surface to modern detail
- no visible combat emphasis, weapon posing, or action framing
- no busy HUD, verb bars, minimaps, readable debug text, or inventory clutter
- no ordinary Earth sidewalks, storefronts, suburban trim, or modern concrete realism
- no over-bloomed emissives, crushed black AO, or mirror-finish metals everywhere
- no faux “retro” artifacts that make the image ugly instead of evocative

The best short test is this: **if the image reads like a dramatic game environment but not like a place that has been waiting for centuries, it is off-style.**

Technical implementation

Rendering model and color pipeline

Use a scene-linear workflow from the beginning of production. Unity states directly that linear color space produces more accurate rendering, and both Unity and Blender describe color texture sampling through sRGB conversion while preserving linear treatment for utility maps and physically meaningful calculations. Blender’s manuals also position scene-linear as the best space for rendering and compositing, and note that non-color images should be marked as Non-Color Data. ⁶

For cross-tool consistency, adopt a shared OpenColorIO configuration wherever possible. Unreal’s OCIO workflow is built around a configuration asset that manages the profiles you work with, and Blender’s color management is based on the same library. In a studio setting, that means color decisions for concept paintovers, DCC lookdev, and engine output can be normalized instead of eyeballed per application. ⁷

Use the following texture data conventions as a project standard.

Map type	Color space	Typical compression	Mips	Notes
Base Color	sRGB	BC7 on DX11-class targets; DXT1/DXT5 fallback	Yes	Keep free of explicit directional lighting in the full PBR path
Emissive Color	sRGB or linear HDR depending pipeline	BC7 / HDR-capable format as needed	Yes	Glow should come from emission + bloom, not just painted white cores
Normal	Linear / Non-Color	BC5 preferred where available	Yes	Tangent-space normals; UVs must match

Map type	Color space	Typical compression	Mips	Notes
ORM / packed roughness-metallic-AO	Linear / Non-Color	BC7 / BC3 / platform pack	Yes	Pack channels for efficiency
Opacity / mask	Linear / Non-Color	BC4 / BC7 / alpha container	Yes	Use masked when possible for stable edges
UI frame	sRGB	Uncompressed or high-quality color compression	No	Non-scaled UI gets no benefit from mipmaps

This convention is not arbitrary. Unity's docs specify that color textures generally require sRGB conversion, while normal maps and other non-color textures do not. Unity and Unreal also both tie mip/streaming behavior to appropriately authored texture assets, and Unreal's texture guidance emphasizes the importance of power-of-two sizing for streamed mipmapped textures. ⁸

Materials and shaders

For the full-fidelity path, base materials on a conventional PBR model and stylize through **shape, roughness control, palette, and grading**, not through physically incoherent values. Unreal's material documentation emphasizes Roughness, Metallic, and Specular as the core controls, and notes that the default specular value of 0.5 corresponds to roughly 4% reflectance, which is appropriate for the vast majority of non-metals. In practice, that means stone, ceramic, painted surfaces, and glass should usually keep specular near default and do most of their look work through roughness and normal behavior. ⁹

Do not paint hard sunlight or fake deep shadow directly into albedo in the main PBR path. Unreal's archiviz guidance is explicit that base color should be free of lighting information. For *The Horizon Archive*, the painterly feeling should instead come from macro color design, hand-authored value breakup, cavity masks, subtle overlays, and final grade. If a legacy path is needed for a more aggressively retro look, limited ambient painting in diffuse is acceptable, but it should be broad and architectural, not illustrative. ¹⁰

For transparent or translucent elements, distinguish carefully between **cheap transparency, physically based glass**, and **retro fallback cheats**. Unreal's standard translucent blend mode historically lacks proper specular, while Thin Translucent / tinted-glass workflows support white specular highlights and correctly tinted background color. In Unity, alpha-blended assets should be placed in the transparent render queue and rendered after opaque geometry, with the usual caveats about sorting and depth writes. For bloom-engine petals, alien glass, oracle membranes, or shield screens, prefer physically based thin translucent approaches in the modern path; in the legacy path, use masked or dithered transparency plus Fresnel and cubemap reflection rather than expensive refraction. ¹¹

If a stylized dither, grain, or low-bit patina pass is used, place it late in the image pipeline. Unreal's post-process material documentation notes that after-tonemapper placement is the preferred location for performance when the intention is to modify the final LDR image. That makes it the correct home for a subtle ordered-dither or screenshot-patina pass that should sit on top of the finished scene rather than influence lighting itself. ¹²

Material target table

Material	Visual target	PBR target range	Legacy fallback	Common uses
Basalt stone	ancient, heavy, light-eating	Metallic 0, Roughness 0.78–0.96, default specular	diffuse + cavity AO + low normal	ruins, terraces, alley walls, monoliths
Carved black stone	ceremonial, incised, damp	Metallic 0, Roughness 0.65–0.9, subtle wet variation	hand-painted value split	obelisks, steps, relic ribs
Oxidized metal	old, noble, exposed in patches	Metallic 1 where bare; oxide masks non-metal; Roughness 0.35–0.75	cubemap spec + painted wear	robot joints, frames, cables
Ceramic shell	heat-shielded, practical, aged	Metallic 0, Roughness 0.45–0.8	diffuse with gentle edge wear	domes, suit panels, thermal shields
Thin translucent petal glass	sacred bio-engineering	Metallic 0, Roughness 0.05–0.25 with frosted patches, tinted transmission	alpha-dither + Fresnel + cubemap	meadow petals, lab membranes
Emissive veins / seams	internal life or archive signal	HDR emissive multiplied by mask; bloom from threshold	additive sprite/post glow	oracle veins, robot eye, city seams
Reflective puddle / shallow pool	quiet mirror, not chrome	Metallic 0, Roughness 0.02–0.15 + ripple noise	planar fake / cubemap	ruins water, alley puddles
Lava / hot core	controlled extreme heat	emissive core with rough crust variation	painted heat + distortion card	volcano channels, vents

Asset production guidelines

Power-of-two texture sizing is strongly recommended for any asset expected to mipmap or stream. Unreal's texture import guide says textures should be powers of two for mipmap use; Unity's mipmap documentation likewise ties auto-generated mipmaps to power-of-two sources, and Unreal also notes that power-of-two textures can be mipmapped and streamed while non-power-of-two textures do not generate mips in the same way. Use that as a hard rule for environment content, even if some UI and concept-delivery assets stay outside it. ¹³

Mipmap and streaming behavior should be part of the art spec, not an afterthought. Unity's docs note that mipmaps reduce artifacts and can improve performance when textures are rendered at lower-than-full resolution, while texture streaming loads only the needed mip levels to reduce memory use. That is particularly relevant for *The Horizon Archive*, where large landscapes, city shots, and repeated architecture

dominate the frame. The one major exception is UI: Unity explicitly notes that mipmaps provide no benefit for textures always rendered at full resolution, such as non-scaled UI textures. ¹⁴

Compression choice should follow target platform. Direct3D's BC documentation and Unity's platform recommendations align on the major rule: BC7 is the best high-quality compressed color option for DX11-class targets, BC6H is appropriate for HDR color, BC5 is a strong two-channel choice and therefore a natural recommendation for normal-map-style data, and BC-class compression can reduce memory footprint substantially compared with uncompressed 32-bit color. Where BC7 is unsupported, DXT5-class fallbacks remain practical. ¹⁵

For mesh simplification and baking, use conventional real-time practices. Unity's LOD documentation treats decreasing-detail meshes as a standard optimization technique; Blender's Decimate modifier is explicitly intended to reduce face count with minimal shape changes; and Blender's baking tools are designed for exporting base color, normal, AO, and light information to game engines. That is exactly the discipline needed here: preserve silhouette, collapse tertiary geometry, and bake what the player will perceive as texture rather than form. ¹⁶

For repeated assets such as meadow flowers, monolith families, bridge supports, suit extras, or volcanic city modules, use instancing selectively. Unity's GPU instancing and Unreal's instanced static mesh workflows are both intended to render multiple copies of the same mesh more efficiently, while still allowing per-instance variation such as color or scale. This is ideal for Horizon Archive scenes because the style depends on repeated ceremonial motifs without obvious duplication. ¹⁷

Asset specification table

Asset type	Target LOD0 polycount	Typical texture size	LODs	Production note
Hero relic / landmark	20k–60k tris	2×2K sets or 1×4K atlas	4	silhouette matters far more than microgeometry
Midground architecture module	1.5k–12k tris	512–1K atlas, occasional 2K	3	kit pieces must instance cleanly
Monolith / obelisk	800–5k tris	512–1K	3	keep faceting visible, avoid over-beveling
Hero robot / close character	15k–35k tris	2K color, 1K–2K data	4	face/body language through silhouette, not face rig detail
Worker / suited NPC	6k–15k tris	1K atlas	3	background-readable, not face-readable
Foliage / flower cluster	100–1.2k tris	256–512	2–3	instance aggressively; use hue and scale variation
VFX card / particle sheet	minimal	128–512	n/a	use slow motion and sparse density

Asset type	Target LOD0 polycount	Typical texture size	LODs	Production note
UI textbox frame	vector or very low poly	2K×512 or 4K×1024 raster	n/a	no mips; preserve hard trim edges
Matte background master	3D blockout + paintover	4K–6K master	n/a	deliver flattened background and separated UI

Hand-painted vs baked balance. For this project, a **70/30 bias toward hand-authored shape and value** is usually correct. Use bake-derived normal/AO data to reinforce surface truth, but do not let photo-baked micro-noise dominate the frame. The image must still feel composed.

Texel density guidance. For fixed-camera work, target what the camera can actually see: hero interactables around the camera focus zone can justify 512–1024 px/m effective density; distant architecture may only need 64–128 px/m. Spend density where the shot composition spends attention.

Character and costume design rules

Character design in *The Horizon Archive* should be **silhouette-first and emotionally legible at distance**. Even in the robot alley scene, the important information is not facial animation fidelity; it is posture, head tilt, damaged asymmetry, seam light, and the way the figure occupies architectural space.

Use the following rules.

Robots and sentient machines. They should look like durable tools that have outlived their era: chipped housings, exposed cable muscles, visible fasteners, cracked optics, missing plates, and uneven weight distribution. Avoid superhero anatomy, glossy skin, or cute compactness. The machine should feel like a witness or steward.

Environmental suits. Heat suits, archive suits, and exploration gear should be honest engineering. Build them from layered insulation, reflective plating, sealed joints, cooling packs, heavy gloves and boots, and a single readable visor shape. Keep the silhouette rugged and a little cumbersome. Never make them sleek power armor.

Color discipline. Characters should not introduce new palette families. Their accents should be borrowed from the environment: violet eye light in the alley, ceramic ash in the volcanic city, muted brass or black stone in ruins.

Detail budget. Use three levels of read: large silhouette masses, medium function panels, minimal tertiary seams. If a feature is only readable at portrait distance and the camera never goes there, remove it.

Relic and architecture language

The architecture of *The Horizon Archive* should feel **non-human without becoming decorative nonsense**. The reference set suggests a grammar built from faceted verticals, suspended masses, rib-like supports,

terraces, shallow canals, giant petals, cages, and monolith fields. Repetition is welcome, but it should feel ceremonial or infrastructural rather than modular in a modern industrial sense.

Form rules

- Prefer **faceted planes** over soft subdivisions.
- Let large shapes dominate. One giant petal, pillar, or dome is more on-style than thirty small props.
- Use **cant, lean, suspension, and offset symmetry** rather than ordinary bilateral exactness.
- Build ornament into structure: notches, channels, ribs, apertures, vents, pylons.
- Keep doorways and thresholds ambiguous. Many spaces should feel *almost* scaled for people, not comfortably so.

Erosion rules

- Stone should chip at edges, stratify, stain, and collect mineral residue.
- Metals should oxidize in patches rather than uniformly rust.
- Ceramics should craze, soot, and chalk.
- Living relics should fiber, drift, seed, or glow through seams.
- Volcanic architecture should show thermal zoning: cooler shell, hotter seams, ash deposition.

Scale rules

Scale should be communicated indirectly: tiny figures on bridges, stair runs that take several beats to climb, monoliths that frame a relic without equaling it, algae lines on submerged ruins, or petals that dwarf pools and pathways.

UI integration and export specifications

The UI should always read as part of the same archaeological interface language as the world. Treat the textbox as a carved instrument panel recovered from the same civilization, not a modern flat-overlay app component.

For art production, deliver UI and scene as separate layers even when the final concept image bakes them together. Recommended deliverables for each key shot are:

- **background master** without textbox, in scene-linear high bit depth if part of render pipeline
- **textbox frame** as separate raster or vector element
- **final comp** at target output resolution with box included
- **grade LUT or note sheet** if the shot depends on a specific per-scene grade
- **mask pass** for local fog, bloom, or front-layer cards if the shot will be reused in engine

If the runtime implementation uses raster UI textures, disable mipmaps for the textbox frame unless it will genuinely scale at runtime. Unity's documentation is clear that non-scaled UI textures do not benefit from mips. For concept-delivery and marketing stills, keep the box present but empty or visually unreadable. ¹⁸

If a subtle final dither or archival patina overlay is part of the runtime look, add it as a late post pass after tonemapping and grading so it sits on the final image instead of interfering with scene lighting and bloom thresholds. ¹²

Production pipeline and review

Art pass stages

A studio implementation should begin with **shot-first lookdev**, not with asset accumulation. The visual identity of *The Horizon Archive* is inseparable from its camera grammar; therefore camera lock, box placement, palette, atmosphere, and wonder hierarchy must be approved before deeper asset production begins.

The most reliable concept-art workflow is:

1. **Grayscale blackout** with textbox already present.
2. **Tier-one subject lock** at thumbnail scale.
3. **Atmosphere pass** to establish depth and world intelligence.
4. **Scene accent family** assignment.
5. **Material family pass** for stone / metal / ceramic / luminous matter.
6. **Foreground and scale cue pass.**
7. **Final grade and UI integration.**

For fixed-camera 2D backgrounds, use a hybrid pipeline. Build a rough 3D blackout for perspective and scale, lock the camera, render a neutral base, then paint over while preserving faceted masses and large atmospheric shapes. Keep parallax layers minimal if the background must be interactive in engine. This avoids turning the scene into modern free-camera realism while preserving perspective rigor.

For fully 3D runtime scenes, the same order applies, but lighting and atmosphere must be tuned as if you were still building a background plate. The objective is not maximum navigability; it is *locked-frame readability and mood*.

Implementation roadmap

```
gantt
title Sample studio rollout for The Horizon Archive visual style
dateFormat YYYY-MM-DD

section Lookdev
Reference analysis and palette lock           :a1, 2026-05-11, 7d
Textbox and UI frame kit                     :a2, after a1, 5d
Master material prototype library            :a3, after a1, 10d

section Vertical slice
Camera sheets and blockouts for benchmark scenes :b1, after a2, 10d
Hero relic and robot benchmark assets          :b2, after a3, 10d
Atmosphere, bloom, fog, and grade tuning      :b3, after b1, 10d

section Production
Environment modular kits                      :c1, after b3, 20d
```

Character and suit pass	:c2, after b3, 15d
Background comps and UI integration	:c3, after c1, 10d
section Polish	
LOD, instancing, texture streaming review	:d1, after c2, 10d
Final consistency review and grading	:d2, after c3, 5d

Milestone	Duration	Deliverables	Review focus
Reference lock	1 week	palette sheet, composition rules, textbox spec	does everything still feel like the same game?
UI frame kit	<1 week	final textbox border family, margins, blank-state comps	is the box quiet but unmistakable?
Master materials	1.5 weeks	stone, metal, ceramic, translucent, emissive, lava	are roughness and glow doing the work, not gloss?
Vertical slice shot kit	2 weeks	one meadow shot, one ruins shot, one encounter shot, one city shot	does the style survive different scales and moods?
Asset library buildout	3–4 weeks	kits, hero relics, characters, VFX cards	are motifs repeating without obvious duplication?
Technical polish	2 weeks	LODs, instancing, compression, texture streaming, final LUT	does performance stay stable without aesthetic loss?

Sample asset list for a benchmark package

Package	Contents	Purpose
Relic benchmark set	bloom-engine, gravity frame, 3 minor shrine props	verifies wonder hierarchy
Ruin kit	monoliths, steps, terrace slabs, shallow pool trims	verifies modular architecture language
Encounter kit	alley walls, puddles, light niches, decayed robot	verifies intimate staging
Volcanic infrastructure kit	domes, bridges, vents, railings, thermal barriers, suited worker	verifies social scale and engineering realism
Atmosphere kit	pollen, seam-light flicker, steam plume, heat shimmer, dust motes	verifies active air
UI kit	textbox frame, mask variants, dark fill presets	verifies narrative anchor

QA checklist for style consistency

Check	Pass if	Fail if
Textbox ratio	lower quarter is clearly reserved and visually stable	UI is too shallow, too tall, or absent
Thumbnail readability	the main wonder reads instantly at small size	the eye wanders or focal point is unclear
Atmosphere	haze, pollen, damp air, or heat distortion is visibly active	scene looks optically clean or over-literal
Material family	stone, metal/ceramic, and luminous matter feel related	assets look from different games
Palette discipline	one cool base, one accent family	many unrelated saturated colors compete
Retro abstraction	silhouette leads detail, faceting remains visible	microdetail turns the scene into generic realism
Glow restraint	bloom only appears around true bright regions	everything glows
AO restraint	contact and crevice darkening only	black grime fills half the image
Non-human world feel	architecture is legible but not Earth-normal	scene reads like a modern city or fantasy town
Character styling	silhouette and posture lead emotional read	face detail, armor polish, or hero posing dominate
UI silence	no readable text in concept/export shots	placeholder gibberish or accidental text appears
Technical sanity	correct color spaces, mips, compression, LODs, instancing applied	runtime artifacts or memory waste undermine the shot

Appendices

Example prompt template for scene generation

Create a 16:9 image in the established visual style of The Horizon Archive.

CORE STYLE:

Painterly PS1-inspired low-poly point-and-click adventure game screen; fixed camera; ancient alien archaeology; mystery through abstraction; serious and beautiful tone; faceted forms; disciplined fog/haze; one dominant wonder; bottom blank textbox occupying 25% of frame.

SUBJECT / SCENE:

[Describe the discovery, location, encounter, or city.]

COMPOSITION:

Scene occupies 75% of frame; textbox occupies 25% at bottom.

Use a static cinematic adventure-game camera.

Establish strong foreground, midground, and background.

Make the main subject instantly readable at thumbnail size.

Include a wide empty dark textbox with a thin decorative stone/metal sci-fi border and no readable text.

VISUAL LANGUAGE:

Ancient non-human architecture; dark stone, aged metal/ceramic, controlled luminous or translucent matter; muted indigo/violet/black/ash palette with one scene-specific accent family.

ATMOSPHERE:

Add scene-appropriate haze: fog, pollen, damp air, heat shimmer, dust, steam, or star distortion.

Keep the scene quiet, eerie, and awe-oriented rather than action-oriented.

NEGATIVE PROMPT:

No readable text, no logos, no modern glossy realism, no generic sleek sci-fi, no fantasy runes, no busy HUD, no combat framing, no cute mascots, no anime, no ordinary Earth architecture.

Example art brief template for a production shot

Shot title:

Scene type:

Narrative purpose:

Primary wonder:

Secondary guidance elements:

Atmosphere type:

Accent palette:

Scale cues:

Camera lens target:

Textbox state:

Interactive hotspots implied:

Forbidden motifs:

Reference scene family:

- meadow
- ruins
- encounter
- volcanic city

Example asset brief template for a 3D hero prop

Asset name:
Scene family:
Role in hierarchy:
Silhouette description:
Primary material:
Secondary material:
Emissive / translucent behavior:
LOD0 target polycount:
Texture set budget:
Will normals be baked from high-resolution source?
Will ORM be packed?
Required instances / variants:
Distance at which asset is viewed:
Notes on erosion / age / damage:
Off-style risks:

Reference breakdown recap

Reference	Core lesson	Camera mode	Accent family	Key material note
Meadow relic	beauty can still be uncanny	central establishing shot	pale green, mauve, dawn gold	translucent petals need sacred, not fantasy, handling
Cosmic ruins	science-mystic scale without fantasy	ritual platform frontal shot	violet, indigo, starlight	black stone + luminous geometry
Fallen automaton	intimacy without losing world tone	close static alley dialogue	ultraviolet, rust-black	character as relic, not mascot
Volcanic city	bustle and realism can still fit	elevated overlook shot	ember orange, ceramic ash	infrastructure must feel engineered, not infernal

Printable quick-reference cheat sheet

Page one

Topic	Default
Core principle	Mystery through abstraction
One-sentence direction	Lost late-1990s sci-fi adventure screenshot; playable archaeology

Topic	Default
Frame	16:9
Layout	75% scene / 25% textbox
Camera	fixed, 32–45 mm establishing; 45–60 mm encounter
Focal logic	one dominant wonder
Material family	black stone + aged metal/ceramic + luminous/translucent matter
Palette rule	cool mineral base + one accent family
Atmosphere rule	at least one active air effect in every scene
Tone	quiet, serious, sacred, impossible

Page two

Topic	Default
Color workflow	scene-linear
Color textures	sRGB
Normal / ORM / masks	linear / non-color
Environment textures	power-of-two with mipmaps
UI frame textures	no mips if not scaled
Preferred desktop color compression	BC7 for color, BC6H for HDR, BC5-style recommendation for two-channel data
Repeated scenery	instance selectively
Simplification	preserve silhouette, collapse tertiary form
Bloom	thresholded, sparse
AO	subtle only
Transparency	use physically based tinted glass where needed; otherwise masked/dithered cheats
Absolute bans	readable text in concept shots, busy HUD, sleek generic sci-fi, fantasy runes, photorealism

Open questions and limitations

The guide above is rigorous at the level of visual language and production defaults, but two implementation decisions remain project-specific and should be locked by the studio before full production:

1. **Primary runtime mode:** fixed-camera pre-rendered backgrounds with live props, or fully 3D locked-camera scenes. The guide supports both, but the pipeline, performance envelope, and texture budgets should be finalized early.
2. **Render target profile:** DX11-class desktop/console, lower-spec fallback, or multi-target release. Compression choices, volumetric density, transparency quality, and atmosphere complexity should be tuned once the shipping platforms are confirmed.

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